FOR LAUGHS



THE OUTSIDER
A MEMOIR FOR MISFITS
By Vir Das
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 288 pages

pany, Weirdass Comedy. "Once politicians started coming for me, it kind of proved what I'd been saying; India is a country that does not want to air its dirty laundry," he writes.

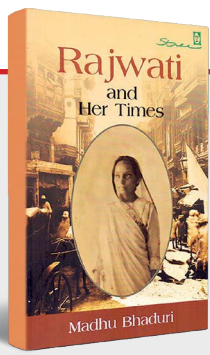
As an author, he is not afraid to share some of his gaffes, particularly his attempt at being a VJ, doing films like *Mastizaade* and a US show, *Whisky Cavalier,* which didn't propel his career in Hollywood as hoped. *The Outsider* works best when Das dwells on the personal, especially when recalling the time spent living with his grandparents in New Delhi or the succinct chapter about his childhood in Lagos, where he lived till the age of nine.

Das traverses through his life, ticking off life-changing experiences (many unfold in the US), accomplishments, relationships and ambitions. There's not much insight about his creative process, particularly as a stand-up artist, but there's some reflection on being an English-speaking comedian and trying to find an audience in that limited landscape, as well as an actor in Bollywood. Hence, the book title. There's some humble-bragging, especially when it comes to adventures in comedy clubs in the US and some truth bombs ("... the benchmark of a truly secure leader is their ability to tolerate satire"). That's as political as the book gets.

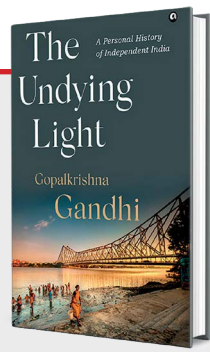
THE COMIC FINALLY OPENS UP ON THE IMPACT HIS YOUTUBE SPECIAL 'TWO INDIAS' HAD ON HIM EMOTIONALLY AND PROFESSIONALLY

If you are going into this book expecting laughs as you do from Das's specials, then this may not be what you're looking for. Perhaps the funniest bit here is when he equates his *Delhi Belly* co-actor Imran Khan, who makes a comeback with *Happy Patel*, to Ryan Gosling, not once but at least four times. Instead, tears are more likely to flow as Das devotes a chapter to his deceased British bulldog Watson and the impact he had on him. It's Das at his most vulnerable and honest as he speaks of how the doggo saved his marriage. ■

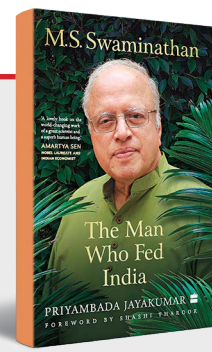
—Suhani Singh



RAJWATI AND HER TIMES
By Madhu Bhaduri
STREE BOOKS
₹500; 105 pages



THE UNDYING LIGHT
A Personal History of Independent India
By Gopalkrishna Gandhi ALEPH
₹999; 624 pages



M.S. SWAMINATHAN
The Man Who Fed India
By Priyambada Jayakumar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹799; 324 pages

on her premiership despite covering well-trodden terrain. *Mohan and Muhammad*, Meghnad Desai's posthumously published study of Mahatma Gandhi and M.A. Jinnah, is a slim volume but full of insights about the how and whys of Partition.

Himanshu Prabha Ray and Ajay Yadav's *Indian Archaeology after Independence* is a study of Amalananda Ghosh, the ASI's longest-serving Indian director general. This gives a different perspective to the more familiar trope of famous colonial-era DGs—Cunningham, Marshall and Wheeler—and reveals much about the ASI and archaeology in India and the substantial impress Ghosh left on them.

Narayani Basu's *A Man for All Seasons*, a biography of K.M. Panikkar, is an admirable, very comprehensive account of the many different avatars Panikkar had—teacher and historian, journalist, courtier, diplomat and finally his role in the States Reorganisation Commission.

I also enjoyed Arun Shourie's icon-busting account of V.D. Savarkar in *The New Icon*, and Priyambada Jayakumar's *M.S. Swaminathan: The Man Who Fed India* very accessibly fills the gap in knowledge about a scientist who played a transformative role. It also restores some balance in favour of scientists who are often overlooked in preference to politicians and civil servants. ■